



and also gave rise to both power struggles and many ceremonies. There is still a strong and innovative tradition of craftwork among the Ashanti. A new tradition was born in the 1960s when a talented sculptor created the

first fantasy coffin in the shape of a fish for his dying uncle who was a fisherman. In keeping with the lavish and lengthy funerals customary in Ghana, the idea was an immediate and lasting hit.



#### THE SEAT OF POWER

During the early days of the Ashanti Kingdom, a Golden Stool summoned by the high priest descended from heaven and came to rest on the knees of the first *asantebene*, Osei Tutu. This stool, still used in enstoolment ceremonies today, came to symbolize the soul and power of the Ashanti people and their king.

#### A SINGLE PIECE OF WOOD

Stools are a typically Ashanti item and are often made of soft sese or cedar wood. Craftsmen are exceptionally skilled and do not measure the wood; they simply begin carving it with a tool called an adze.

Craftsmen sometimes incorporate images into the design that reflect the personality of the owner.



#### FANTASY COFFINS

Specially commissioned coffins in the form of airplanes, chickens, guitars, or even giant Bibles celebrate the achievements of the person who has died and enable them to go on their final journey in style.

